

Global Digital Assets

Emerging AI Infra: ERCOT base load classifications are out - scarcity expected to drive lease pricing higher



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Emerging AI infrastructure developers have so far disclosed 8 GW of conditional base load and another 7 GW of conditional studied load classification from ERCOT. While the power pipelines of most AI developers remain reliant on the Texas grid, a conditional baseload designation provides greater near term visibility into power availability and project execution timelines. This also opens up the base load sites for lease negotiations and would expect scarcity of base load sites to continue driving lease pricing higher.

Of the total 8 GW of base load classification, over 5 GW is available to be contracted for AI deployments, including two gigawatt campuses with IREN (2 GW Sweetwater campus) and CIFR (1 GW Colchis). In our view, approved capacity is becoming increasingly valuable amid growing political scrutiny of new data center developments and capacity constraints driven by moratoriums and state level directives. Through the screening process, ERCOT has also reclassified some projects initially submitted as Base load into the Studied load category, implying lower base load allocation than previously expected. In our coverage, CIFR submitted 3.6 GW sites as potential Batch Zero candidates, however have received incremental approval for only 1 GW.

Conditional Batch Zero status disclosed by miners:

(i) IREN: Sweetwater hub (2 GW) has received conditional approval to be included as Base load.

(ii) CIFR: Cipher has received conditional classification for 1.1 GW (1 GW Colchis and 100 MW Stingray) base load and 2.1 GW (500 MW Mikeska, 500 MW McLennan, 900 MW Apollo, 200 MW Stingray Phase II) studied load.

(ii) CLSK: CLSK received conditional designation for the entire Texas portfolio (under exclusivity arrangement with Sandersville tenant) - 285 MW at Sealy and 300 MW at Brazoria classified as base load, while 300 MW Phase 2 at Brazoria classified as studied load.

(iii) CORZ: CORZ has announced base load classification for Hunt (431 MW) and Pecos (300 MW). Additional 300 MW expansion at Pecos is categorized as studied load. While 371 MW at Denton is not subject to the Batch Zero process.

(vi) MARA: MARA has received conditional base load classification for Granbury (~280 MW) and Garden City sites (~200 MW). Matagorda site (up to 2 GW) has been classified as studied load.

(v) HUT (not covered): Hut 8's 1 GW Beacon Point campus has received conditional Base load classification.

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(vi) GLXY (not covered): Helios I (800 MW) and II (830 MW) are conditionally classified as Base load. While 3 projects Caspian (700 MW - originally submitted as base load), Selene (900 MW) and Helios III (1 GW) are classified as studied load.

(vii) Soluna (not covered): 166 MW Kati campus and 100 MW at Dorothy campus have received conditional Base load classification.

ERCOT's Batch Zero process and Texas data center audits: ERCOT's Batch Zero is the first cohort of projects being evaluated under a system-wide study that allocates the available transmission capacity. Batch Zero projects are classified as Base load, Studied load or Excluded projects. Base load includes operating projects and advanced developments supported by qualifying prior studies. These projects are not subject to further evaluation or MW reallocation. Studied load projects require system-level analysis to determine the amount and timing of approved capacity, with no assurance that the full requested load will ultimately be granted. Projects classified as Excluded will be considered in future application rounds, with Batch 1 submissions expected to begin in Summer 2027.

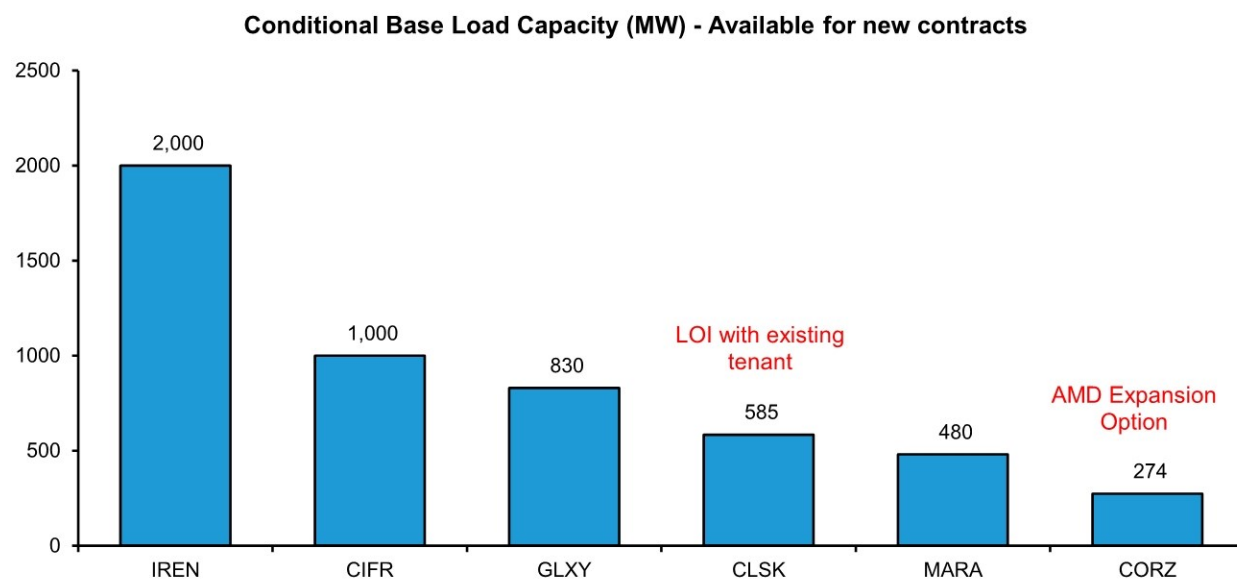
ERCOT completed its first Batch Zero screening on September 3 and notified the Distribution and Transmission Service Providers (TDSPs) of the provisional classifications assigned to large-load projects. These classifications are conditional, subject to passing Governor Abbott's audit among other requirements. ERCOT currently expects the formal Batch Zero verification report to be released in December 2026.

We continue to like AI infra players in our coverage with secured power and strong uncontracted pipelines. We see evolving grid regulations as an opportunity to decongest the grid by removing speculative queue positions and make genuine sites with development history more valuable. Studied load allocation is not being finalized until atleast April 2027 (ERCOT's original deadline). In our view, this strengthens the competitive position of operators with conditional Base Load capacity. We are Outperform on CIFR, WULF, IREN, CORZ, CLSK and RIOT.

EXHIBIT 1: Miner's power portfolio - Texas exposure

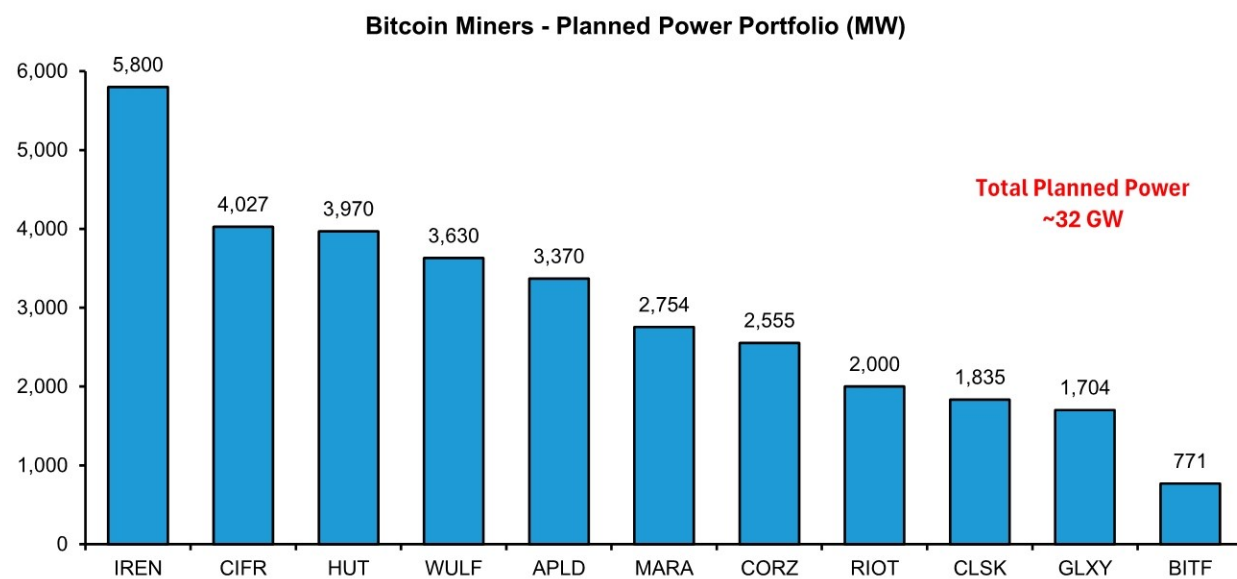
	Site	Capacity	Conditional Classification - Batch Zero
Announced so far -8 GW base load and 7 GW studied load			
IREN	Sweetwater Campus	2 GW	Base load
CLSK	Sealy	285 MW	Base load
	Brazoria	300 MW	Base load
	Brazoria Phase II	300 MW	Studied load
CORZ	Pecos I	300 MW	Base load
	Pecos II	300 MW	Studied load
	Denton	371 MW	Approved, not subject to Batch Zero
	Hunt	431 MW	Base load
HUT	Beacon Point	1 GW	Base load
GLXY	Helios I and II	1.6 GW	Base load
	Caspian, Selene, Helios III	2.6 GW	Studied load
MARA	Granbury	280 MW	Base load
	Garden City	200 MW	Base load
	Matagorda	2 GW	Studied load
Soluna	Kati	166 MW	Base load
	Dorothy	100 MW	Base load
CIFR	Colchis, Stingray	1.1 GW	Base load
	Apollo	0.9 GW	Studied load
	Mikeska, McLennan, Stingray Phase II	1.2 GW	Studied load

Source: Company filings, Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 2: **Bitcoin miners have 5 GW+ base load capacity available for new AI deployments**

CORZ includes 192 IT MW at Hunt

Source: Company filings, Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 3: **Bitcoin miners' power advantage: Access to ~32GW planned power across key data center markets**

HUT incl. 1.9GW power in exclusivity; CIFR incl. new 900MW Apollo site; MARA excludes 2 GW Matagorda site; APLD as of May 2026

Source: Company filings, Bernstein analysis

INVESTMENT IMPLICATIONS

Crypto miners remain well positioned to solve 'time to compute' given their planned ~32GW power portfolio and operating ability to deliver 'warm powered shells' in time. Over the past two years, miners have contracted ~9GW of power capacity to hyperscalers, frontier AI labs, neoclouds and AI-chip manufacturers across 20+ deals worth over \$180Bn. We rate WULF Outperform (PT\$36), CIPR Outperform (PT\$32), IREN Outperform (PT\$100), CORZ Outperform (PT\$32), RIOT Outperform (PT\$35), CLSK Outperform (PT\$24), and MARA Market-Perform (PT\$17).

BERNSTEIN TICKER TABLE

			15 Sep 2026	TTM		Reported EPS				Reported P/E (x)		
			Closing	Price	Rel.							
Ticker	Rating	Cur	Price	Target	Perf.	Cur	2025A	2026E	2027E	2025A	2026E	2027E
CIPR (Cipher)	O	USD	15.09	32.00	24.4%	USD	(2.15)	(1.13)	(0.53)	(7.0)	(13.3)	(28.5)
WULF (TeraWulf)	O	USD	14.49	36.00	23.5%	USD	(1.66)	(1.66)	(0.71)	(8.7)	(8.8)	(20.3)
CORZ (Core Scientific)	O	USD	16.04	32.00	(16.4)%	USD	(0.88)	(0.92)	0.26	(18.2)	(17.4)	61.7
MARA (MARA)	M	USD	11.24	17.00	(45.5)%	USD	(3.69)	3.29	(1.22)	(3.0)	3.4	(9.2)
IREN (IREN)	O	USD	41.58	100.00	(2.7)%	USD	(2.20)	(2.66)	0.25	(18.9)	(15.6)	166.6
RIOT (Riot)	O	USD	19.70	35.00	3.4%	USD	(1.95)	0.21	(1.24)	(10.1)	92.0	(15.9)
CLSK (Cleanspark)	O	USD	12.62	24.00	8.0%	USD	1.25	0.08	1.07	10.1	150.9	11.8
SPX			7,585.73									

O - Outperform, M - Market-Perform, U - Underperform, NR - Not Rated, CS - Coverage Suspended

IREN base year is 2026;

Source: Bloomberg, Bernstein estimates and analysis.

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